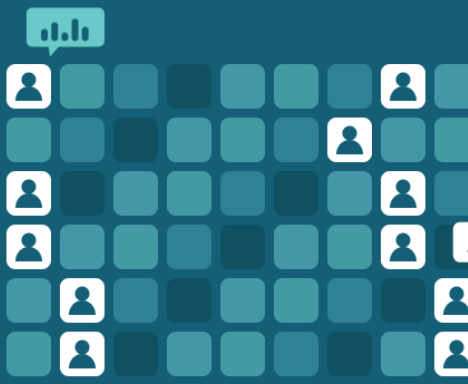
Place-based data training

Activities workbook



This training brings together practical guidance for using data in place-based work. It draws on PLACE and Seer Data's work alongside place-based initiatives across Australia.

The training covers the journey many place-based initiatives go on – from finding and accessing data to sharing it, making sense of it with community and using it to support local decisions and action.

Who is it for?

It is designed for people working in or supporting place-based initiatives. You might be new to working with data or already using and managing data as part of your everyday rhythm.

How to use this workbook

Throughout the training, you'll find opportunities to reflect on your work and consider how the ideas and tools apply in your place or initiative. This workbook brings those activities together in one place, module by module.

You can work through the training from beginning to end, or choose the modules most relevant to your role, experience and current work. We recommend starting with Welcome to place-based data training. You can return to other sections as you need them.

You can also connect with others doing the training to ask questions, share what you're learning and learn from their experience on PLACExCHANGE at **pxc.placeaustralia.org**.

A collaboration between

PLACE
Partnerships for Local Action & Community Empowerment

Seer
Data & Analytics

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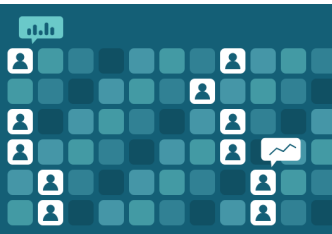
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Module

0 Welcome to place-based data training

Section 1 **Working with data in place-based work** 5 activities

Which of these sounds most like you?

Introduction

- You are already drawing on numbers, stories or observations in your work.
- You know your community deeply and are building your confidence in working with data.
- You want to strengthen how you use data to inform decisions, support learning and understand change.
- You are curious about working with data in place-based work and want to understand what it involves.

My response

Take a moment

Learn

Take a moment: which of the four roles feels most familiar to you? Which would you like to strengthen through this training? Keep that in mind as you move through the modules.

My response

Try this now: take stock of what you already have

Apply Apply to your place 1

You may already be working with more data than you think. Take a few minutes to notice what is already part of your work.

Think about your current work. Identify three examples of data you already use or draw on. For example, this might be:

- Something community members have told you
- Service or program information
- Enrolment, population or other statistics
- A research or evaluation report
- Observations or insights from your work

Add one example to each row below. For each one:

Which source? Which of the four **Place-Based Data buckets** does it fit most closely: Community Insights, Government Data, Service Data, or Research and Evidence?

What does it help me understand? What does this data tell you about your community?

What else might I need to know? What can't you understand from this data alone? What other information or perspectives might help?

What I already have	Which source?	What does it help me understand?	What else might I need to know?

> Now look across your three examples. What do you notice?
>
> Are there particular sources you tend to draw on more than others? What can you understand from what you already have? What questions remain?
>
> This is only a starting point. You don't need data from every source for every question. The important thing is to notice what your existing data can help you understand, and when another source or perspective might help you see something more.

Take a moment

Learn

Take a moment: think about data you already use in your own work. What would it take for the people it describes to feel it was being used respectfully, openly and for their benefit?

My response

Try this now: write down your question

Apply Apply to your place 2

Everything ahead works better if you bring a real question with you.

Think of one question about your community that better data could help you answer. Something people are wondering about, trying to understand or need to make a decision about.

For example: What is changing for young people in our community? Where should we focus our efforts? What are we learning about what is working? Are we beginning to see the changes we hoped for?

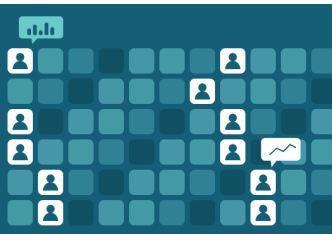
Your question doesn't need to be perfect. Choose something that you would genuinely like to better understand.

Now think about your question from a few different angles:

- Which of the **Four I's** does it most closely relate to? Are you primarily trying to build insight, inform a decision, improve through learning and adaptation, or understand impact?
- Who might need to be involved? Think about who holds relevant knowledge, experience or data, including people in the community, local organisations, service providers, government or others.
- What might you need to consider? Think about whose perspectives are represented, where the data comes from, whether consent or permission is needed, and how the data should be handled and used.

My question	Which of the Four I's does it most closely relate to?	Who might need to be involved?	What might I need to consider when collecting or using data to answer this question?

> Keep your question somewhere you can return to it. Later modules will introduce different ways to explore questions like this, so you can keep applying what you learn to something that matters in your own work.



Module

1.1 Data privacy

Section 1	Understanding the Privacy Act	2 activities
Section 2	Protecting personal information	2 activities
Section 3	Consent and ethical handling	2 activities

Try this now: identify the personal information your initiative works with

Try this now Apply to your place 1

Pick one kind of personal information your initiative works with. Write down the kind of information, not any person's actual details. The first row is an example.

This table is a way to identify the personal information your initiative works with: what it is, who holds it, why it is collected, and whether the Privacy Act applies.

You will add to it in the next exercise.

Information we work with (kind, not details)	Where does it come from/who holds it?	Why is it collected/used?	Does the Privacy Act apply?
Contact details from the school holiday program sign-up form	The neighbourhood centre, which runs the program for the partnership	To confirm places and contact a parent or carer on the day	Not sure. Turnover is under $3 million, so we need to check whether one of the exceptions for smaller organisations applies

Try this now: classify personal and sensitive information

Try this now Apply to your place 2

Go back to the row you started in the exercise above. For that information, name whether it is personal, sensitive or neither, and what extra care it needs.

The information (from the exercise above)	Personal, sensitive or neither?	What makes you classify it this way, and what extra care can you take?
Contact details and allergy notes from the holiday program sign-up form	Personal. The allergy and medication notes are health information, so that part is sensitive	Store it securely, limit who can see it, and only keep it while the program runs

Try this now: identify who covers privacy

Try this now Apply to your place 1

Go back to the information you recorded in Section 1. For each item, identify:

- Which organisation collects, stores or uses the information
- Who you would contact if you had a privacy question or concern
- Which document or process explains how the information is handled
- What you still need to find out

If you do not know an answer, write "Not yet clear".

The information (from Section 1)	Who is responsible for privacy	Which document says so	What I still need to find out
Contact details and allergy notes from the holiday program sign-up form	Nobody yet. The program coordinator collects the forms; the centre manager assumes the partnership handles it	None. The centre has a privacy policy, but the holiday program is not mentioned in it	Who will be the Privacy Lead, and whether the program needs its own privacy notice

Try this now: your initial response plan

Try this now Apply to your place 2

For the information you have been tracking, write down what you would need to know if it ended up somewhere it should not.

If this information leaked, how would we notice?	Who I tell first	Where our response plan is, or who would know	What I do not decide on my own
A parent rings to ask why they got a strange message. There is no alert on the shared drive	The centre manager, the same day, even if I am not sure it is serious	Not sure there is one. The centre manager or backbone coordinator would know	Whether it is serious enough to notify families and the Office of the Australian Information Commissioner. That needs the people named in the plan

Try this now: test one consent process

Try this now | Apply to your place 1

Take one consent process your initiative uses: a form, a verbal question at intake, or a line on a sign-up sheet. Test it against the four elements of valid consent. Answer each column with yes, no or not sure, and add a few words of evidence. Then write the one change that would improve it most.

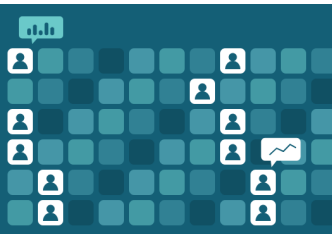
The consent process I am testing	Informed?	Voluntary?	Current and specific?	Capacity?	The one change I would make
Holiday program sign-up form, one tick box	No. It does not say who will see the information	No. One box covers attendance, photos and the newsletter	No. It says “and future programs”, which is undefined	Not sure. A parent signs, but 15- and 16-year-olds sign for themselves	Split the one box into three, and say who sees the information

Try this now: decide – using or sharing?

Try this now | Apply to your place 2

For one piece of information your initiative holds, work through whether you are using it or sharing it, and whether that is allowed.

The information	Am I using it or sharing it?	For the reason it was collected, or a new one?	Allowed, or do I need consent?
A family’s contact details, given to a partner service for a referral	Sharing. The partner is a separate organisation	A new reason. It was collected to run the program, not to refer	I need the family’s consent before sharing



Module

1.2 Data governance

Section 1	Data types	2 activities
Section 2	Keeping data safe	2 activities
Section 3	Legal obligations & data sharing	2 activities

Try this now: name the data your initiative works with

Apply | Apply to your place 1

List two or three sets of data your initiative uses or produces. Do not record any personal or identifying information here: write what the data is about, not what is in it. Name which of the four types it is, and who holds it.

If you are not sure who holds it, write down who you will ask. This is the first part of a data governance record you will build across the module.

What the data is about	Which of the four types	Who holds it	If unsure, who I will ask

Try this now: assign the four responsibilities

Apply Apply to your place 2

The first three columns are filled in: the four responsibilities, who they are usually assigned to, and why each is monitored. Complete the last two columns for your own initiative. Where a responsibility sits with more than one organisation, write both.

For cultural protocols, the question is who holds and guides that responsibility, not what the protocols are: that judgement sits with community.

Responsibility	Usually assigned to	Why it is monitored	Who holds it here	If unsure, who I will ask
Data lifecycle management	Data owners, custodians and stewards	Gives oversight of how data is collected, stored, used, archived, and deleted, which helps prevent misuse, loss or breaches and keeps data accurate over time.		
Quality assurance	Data stewards	Regular checks for accuracy, consistency and completeness are essential to maintain trust and produce reliable insights, and keep decisions sound and evidence-based.		
Access and sharing decisions	Data owners and custodians	Deciding who can access data, on what conditions and for what purpose, supports compliance with privacy laws and ethical agreements, and reduces the risk of unauthorised access or misuse.		
Cultural protocols	Data stewards, owners, and community representatives	Critical for respecting First Nations Data Sovereignty and cultural sensitivities. Monitoring means traditional knowledge and community data are handled with respect, consent, and in line with local governance.		

> **Did you know?** Organisations use data to help with real-world problems, from predicting bushfires to designing mental health services for young people. Good governance ensures that the data is being used for good rather than harm.

Try this now: match the protection to the data

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Take the data you listed in Section 1's first activity and carry it into the table below. For each one, write what governance it needs, using the table above, and who signs off before it can be shared. If you are not sure about sign-off, write down who you will ask.

The data, from Section 1	What governance it needs	Who signs off before it is shared	If unsure, who I will ask

Try this now: check the five practices against your own work

Apply Apply to your place 2

For each practice, mark where your initiative sits: in place, partly, or not yet. Then write the next step and who you would raise it with. You are not expected to fix any of this alone. Naming a gap accurately is a useful contribution.

Practice	In place, partly, or not yet	The next step, and who I would raise it with
Access controls		
Encryption		
Audit trails		
Backup and recovery plans		
Data anonymisation		

Did you know? For many Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples, data is more than information. It is part of cultural identity, knowledge systems, and sovereignty. Strong data security is part of respecting Indigenous data sovereignty and helps protect community-held knowledge from misuse, unauthorised access or inappropriate sharing.

Try this now: check four good practices against a real piece of work

Apply Apply to your place 1

Four practices help data work meet ethical, inclusive and transparent standards as well as legal ones. Pick one piece of data work you have coming up, and check it against all four.

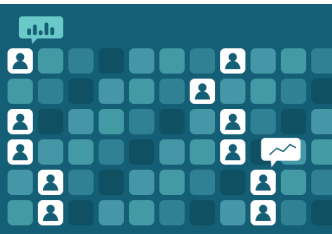
Practice	What it asks of you	What I will do, or what is in place	If unsure, who I will ask
Engage early with communities and stakeholders	Work with communities and stakeholders from the outset to co-design how data will be collected, used, and shared. Keep consent clear, meaningful, and ongoing: people should understand what data is collected, why, who will access it, and how it benefits the community. For First Nations and culturally diverse communities, consent should align with free, prior, and informed consent and respect collective decision-making.		
Maintain transparency across the data lifecycle	Communicate how data is stored, secured, and used, particularly where several partners are involved. Communities should be able to see how their data contributes to local outcomes. Dashboards, reports, or plain-language summaries support openness.		
Embed ethical oversight and reflection	Consider the ethical implications of what you intend to do, to reduce the risk of harm to people taking part. For anything beyond low-risk projects, arrange ethical oversight through review panels or community advisory groups.		
Update internal policies regularly	As privacy laws, technologies, and community expectations change, review and update data governance and privacy policies, so staff and partners stay aware of current standards.		

Try this now: find out what already covers you

Apply Apply to your place 2

Before starting new data work, it helps to check what agreements already exist. Take one piece of data you want access to, or already use, and work through the checks below.

Check	What you are looking for	What I found, or who I will ask
What already exists	An agreement held by your backbone organisation or leadership group. Many initiatives already have data sharing agreements or MOUs in place, and using them keeps you consistent with existing governance.	
A broader partnership agreement	Agreements are sometimes signed at a high level, covering several projects across a partnership. If you work under that partnership, you may already have authority to access the data.	
Governance sign-off	Whether the community governance structure, such as a local data group, leadership table, or advisory board, has reviewed it, so it reflects local values and collective decision-making.	
If nothing covers it	Which option you need, a data sharing agreement or a memorandum of understanding, and why. Use the comparison table above.	
Where you will record it	Where the data came from, under what terms, and what it can be used for.	



Module

1.3 Indigenous Data Sovereignty

Section 1	Understanding Indigenous Data Sovereignty	2 activities
Section 2	Core Indigenous Data Sovereignty principles and the data lifecycle	2 activities
Section 3	Frameworks, guidance and examples in practice	2 activities

Try this now: name the piece of work you will use

Try this now | Apply to your place 1

Pick one piece of work you are involved in now where data connected to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people is used. Write it in the first column, then work across. Name which of the four **data buckets** it involves. Write who holds the data now, and, separately, who holds the authority over it, which are often not the same.

In the last column, write one decision in this work that is not yours to make. If you are not sure about some of the responses, this can be a good time to pause and take the time to find out. If you are not working with data connected to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people right now, use this example instead, and keep using it through the module: your organisation works with several others in a regional town on youth wellbeing.

A government department holds five years of service data for the area, some of it about Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander young people. Your group has been offered access to it for a shared report, and a first meeting is in three weeks.

The piece of work I will use	Which data bucket it involves	Who holds it now / who holds authority over it	One decision here that is not mine to make

Try this now: name the benefit and the risk

Try this now | Apply to your place 2

Go back to the piece of work you named in the earlier exercise. Pick the one benefit above that this work could most realistically support, and the one risk above that is closest if nothing changes. Use the words from the lists, because those are the words a custodian will recognise.

Then name who would need to help decide this and might not be in the conversation yet; a role is enough. If you are unsure, this can be a good point to pause and dig further.

The benefit this work could support	The risk if it is not addressed	Who needs to be in this conversation and is not	One thing I will do this month

Try this now: test your work against the principles

Try this now Apply to your place 1

Take the piece of work from Section 1. Name which of the five Maiam nayri Wingara rights it most affects: control, contextual data, relevance, accountability, or protection. Name which CARE principle it most affects: collective benefit, authority to control, responsibility, or ethics.

Then consider and write how this could be demonstrated. E.g. “A data sharing agreement that names who decides” is something you can show. Finish by considering who in the community you work with/could work with to validate this.

The Maiam nayri Wingara right it most affects	The CARE principle it most affects	How could this be demonstrated?	Who can help validate

Try this now: turning principles into practice

Try this now Apply to your place 2

Return to the example from Section 1 and think about the rights, principles and data you identified in the previous activity.

Consider where Indigenous Data Sovereignty could be strengthened in this work. As you complete the table, you may find it helpful to revisit the descriptions of FPIC, Priority Reform Four, and the Framework for Governance of Indigenous Data.

These approaches provide examples of how governance, capability-building, data access, partnerships and consent can support Indigenous Data Sovereignty in practice.

Area	What could be strengthened?	One practical next step
Partnerships and shared decision-making		
Capability and leadership		
Access to data and information		
Data systems, processes or governance		

Try this now: use frameworks to support community direction

Try this now | Apply to your place 1

Frameworks should support Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander authority, not replace it. Always begin by asking the Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander community, organisation or ACCO what they want and how they want data to be governed.

Then identify which framework, code, commitment or initiative can help you advocate for that direction with someone in your own sphere of influence, such as your executive, a funder, a government agency or a data custodian.

Choose a situation connected to your work and note: What has the community or ACCO asked for? Who needs to support or act on that request? Which framework or commitment strengthens the case? And what would you say to that decision-maker?

What has the community/ACCO asked for?	Who needs to support the request?	Which framework, code, commitment or initiative strengthens the case?	What would you say to the decision-maker/data custodian?

Try this now: applying Indigenous Data Sovereignty in your work

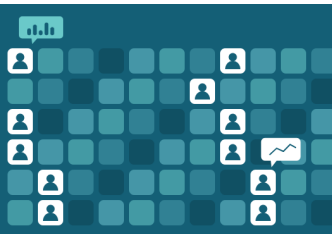
Try this now | Apply to your place 2

The case studies illustrate different ways Indigenous Data Sovereignty can be reflected in practice, including community leadership, governance, strengths-based approaches, local capability, and community ownership of data.

Think about a place-based initiative, project or partnership you are involved in. What would need to change for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people to have greater authority over decisions about data?

If you're not sure, think about what you would need to ask or learn to better understand community priorities and aspirations.

The change needed (or question to explore)	Policy, process or culture change	Whose support is needed	The first conversation, and when



Community insights, data & stories

Module

2.1 Data discovery

Section 1	Find open data, and find who holds it	2 activities
Section 2	Read what the data is telling you	2 activities
Section 3	Run a data conversation everyone can join	2 activities

Try this now: find one dataset for your place

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Pick one of the five areas above, something live in your work right now. Open one source related to it from the Further reading list at the end of this module, and find your own local area. Then fill in the first three columns of the table below.

This table is the start of a data catalogue: each completed row is a line of a spreadsheet you could keep and grow after the module.

In the “One sentence this lets me say” column, write the single sentence this dataset lets you say about your place. Not a summary of the dataset: a sentence you could say out loud in a meeting. In the “What it does not show” column, write one thing this dataset misses about your place.

Title	Description	Source	One sentence this lets me say	What it does not show

Try this now: finish the record

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Go back to the dataset you found earlier and complete its record. Most of this information is on the same page you downloaded the data from. In the quality note, make a note of anything a colleague would want to know.

Custodian and contact	Geography	Time period	Update frequency	Format	Access rules	Quality note

> Record who the custodian is in their own right and who they share data with. This row is the start of a custodian map you can add to as you build your knowledge and relationships.

Custodian	What data they hold	Level (local, regional, state, national)	Role (creates, maintains, or only uses)	Who they share data with

> That is one complete catalogue entry and one custodian recorded. You now have a tool that you did not have before you started this section.
>
> Optional: If you have a question about a local issue and are looking for data to help build understanding, or you'd like to compare what you've found with others, why not start a conversation on the community board?

Try this now: name what you are looking at

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Go back to the dataset catalogue you developed in Section 1 and open its chart or table. Then work through the table below. Write down one thing you can see in it, and name which of the four it is: a shift, a gap, a pattern or a trend. If you would tick two, say which one you would lead with.

Note the period the data covers, then describe whether that timeframe is long enough to support what you just wrote. Finally, name the chart type that would show it best. Like the catalogue in Section 1, this row is a line of a reading log you could keep in a spreadsheet.

One thing I can see	Shift, gap, pattern or trend?	Timeframe the data covers	Is that long enough to support my claim?	Chart type that would show it best

> Tip: the word you choose matters. “Shift” says something moved. “Trend” says it is heading somewhere. Only the timeframe tells you which one you have.

Try this now: write the sentence that goes under the chart

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Take the finding you identified in the previous exercise and complete the table below. First, write the one-sentence key takeaway that would sit underneath the chart: plain language, no acronyms, no source citation in the sentence itself. Read it aloud, and if a sentence feels difficult to follow, try breaking it into smaller parts.

Then write one question you would ask a community member about it, using one of the three from above: does this reflect what you see? what stories sit behind this? what might be influencing this? Finally, name one person you could ask that question to this month.

The sentence that goes under the chart	One question I will ask a community member	One person I could ask this month

> You now have a finding, a sentence, a question and a person. That is a data conversation waiting to happen, which is what Section 3 is about.

Try this now: strip the jargon out of one sentence

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Find one sentence from your recent work: a report, an email, a funding application. Something with a technical term or an acronym in it. Write it in the first column. Then rewrite it for someone with no background in your sector: spell out every acronym, replace every technical word, and put a real number in a human shape, “one in five”, not “20%”.

In the last column, add the honest limitation: one clause naming what this information does not cover. Read the rewrite aloud, and if you run out of breath, cut it in half.

The sentence as it stands	The plain-language rewrite	The honest limitation

Try this now: plan one conversation

Apply Apply to your place 2

Use the finding, the sentence and the person you wrote down in Section 2, and fill in the plan below. Write the one question the session is built around: one question, not three. List the people and groups you will invite, using a stakeholder map so you catch informal leaders and trusted connectors, not only formal roles, and check that nobody who is affected has been left out.

Name a venue and time: somewhere people already go, at a time that suits them rather than you. Note the three things you will bring: which visual, which story or quote, and which way people will respond (sticky notes, a map to mark up, a wall chart).

Then write what you will do in the week afterwards to share back what you heard.

The one question the session is built around	Who I will invite	Venue and time	What I will bring: visual, story, way to respond	How I will share back what I heard

Facilitator's checklist

A facilitator's checklist takes you through the rest, ten checks across the life of the session.

Before the session – plan with intention

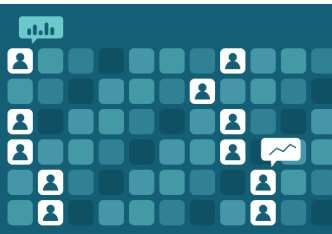
- [ ] Map the voices you need in the room
- [ ] Design for cultural safety
- [ ] Prepare inclusive materials

During the session – facilitate with respect

- [ ] Set the tone early
- [ ] Encourage participation
- [ ] Use flexible creative formats
- [ ] Listen deeply

After the session – reflect and share back

- [ ] Capture what you heard
- [ ] Share back and follow through
- [ ] Reflect and learn



Community insights, data & stories

Module

2.2 Frameworks

Section 1	Choose and adapt a framework for your place	2 activities
Section 2	Agree on shared language and choose indicators people understand	2 activities
Section 3	Read numbers and community voice together	2 activities

Try this now: choose one framework for one piece of work

Apply Apply to your place 1

Pick a piece of work you are involved in right now: a project, a partnership, a plan, a report or a community initiative. Then fill in the table below.

1. Name the work, and the change it is trying to achieve.

2. Choose the framework that best connects that work to the outcomes you want to understand or influence. If none of the four fits, write “none” and name what you would use instead.

3. Write one reason it fits this work.

4. Write one thing the framework will not fully capture about your community, place or context.

This is the first line of your Framework and Indicator Fit Sheet, which you build across the module and could keep as a spreadsheet afterwards.

The piece of work	Framework chosen (Closing the Gap, ARACY Nest, Vital Signs, Measuring What Matters, or none)	One reason it fits this work	One thing it will not capture

Try this now: adapt the framework you chose

Apply Apply to your place 2

Go back to the framework you chose in the exercise “Try this now: choose one framework for one piece of work”, and localise it. You are doing Steps 2 and 3 above in miniature.

1. Find one indicator in that framework that already fits your work and write it down.

2. Write one local indicator you would add; focus on what is relevant to your work and community.

3. Name the role of one person you would ask to check whether that local indicator is the right one: an Elder, a youth worker, a school leader, a resident who has lived there a long time.

4. Note who would need to agree to it, since a local indicator that only your organisation uses is a preference rather than a shared measure.

One national indicator I would keep	One local indicator I would add	Whose role I would ask to check it	Who else would need to agree

Try this now: test three words you use often

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Take the same piece of work you chose in Section 1. Pick three terms that come up regularly, such as wellbeing, engagement, impact, outcomes or participation.

1. Write each term down, and next to it what you mean by it.

2. Name a partner or group who would define it differently, and how.

3. Write the version you would use in a room with community members in it.

Term	What I mean by it	Who would define it differently, and how	The version I would use with community members

Try this now: rewrite one indicator

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Choose one indicator already used in your work: a reporting measure, a funder's metric, something in a dashboard. Then rewrite it.

1. Write the indicator as it reads now, and the outcome it is meant to describe.

2. Rewrite it in the words a community member would use, keeping what it measures.

3. Ask: would this make sense to someone living in our community? Tick or cross.

4. Note anything the rewrite loses, because a plainer indicator that has quietly changed meaning is less useful than a technical one.

The indicator as it reads now	The outcome it is meant to describe	The community-friendly version	Makes sense to someone living here?	What the rewrite loses

Try this now: list the evidence you already hold

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Stay with the same piece of work. This exercise is about what is already in your reach, not what you would collect in an ideal world.

1. Write two pieces of quantitative data you already have access to for this work.

2. Write two pieces of qualitative data you already hold: notes from a community session, something a resident said in a meeting, a service's observation, a survey comment.

3. For each column, write the one thing that this type of evidence cannot tell you here.

Keep any names, addresses or details that identify a person out of this table. What you want is what was said, not who said it.

Quantitative data I already have	Qualitative data I already have	What the numbers cannot tell me here	What the voices cannot tell me here

Try this now: write the strengths-based reading

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Take one issue from the work you have been using in examples, and write the reading you would give it out loud. Four cells, one sentence each.

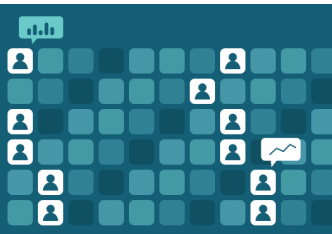
1. What the data shows.

2. What community members say.

3. What strength, relationship, asset or resource already exists here.

4. What new understanding emerges when both are considered together, and what it changes about what you would do next.

What the data shows	What community members say	What strength already exists	What changes when you read them together



Community insights, data & stories

Module

2.3 Data literacy and interpretation

Section 1	Understand charts, trends, and indicators	2 activities
Section 2	Identify gaps, bias, and data limitations	2 activities
Section 3	Reframe challenges as opportunities for change	2 activities

Try this now: choose a chart for one real piece of work

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Pick something you are working on now where you want to show data: a report, a community meeting, a funding update, or a dashboard. Then fill in the table.

1. Name the message you want the data to carry, in one sentence.

2. Choose the chart type that fits that message. Use the simple and advanced tables above.

3. Write one reason it fits the message, not just the chart you already know.

4. Run the five quality checks (accuracy, clarity, balance, context, ethics) and note one thing you need to fix (if applicable).

The message in one sentence	Chart type chosen	One reason it fits	One thing to fix from the quality checks

> Tip: If two chart types both seem to fit, choose the one that makes your main message easiest to see in about ten seconds.

Try this now: read one chart, and write one question

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Choose a chart you have seen recently, from a report, a dashboard, or a news article. Then fill in the table.

1. Name the chart's parts: does it have a clear title, labels, a unit of measure, and a source? Note any that are missing.

2. Write what the numbers are saying, in one sentence.

3. Write one thing the numbers are not saying: a reason, an experience, or a group that may be missing.

4. Write one open, neutral question you could ask to better understand the data.

The chart	What it is saying	What it is not saying	An open question

> Tip: Open questions often start with "How…", "What…", "Tell me about…", or "Can you describe…".

Try this now: test one dataset for gaps and bias

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Choose a dataset you use or rely on. Then fill in the table.

1. Name the dataset and what it is meant to show.

2. Name one group, place, or topic that may help you understand it more fully.

3. Choose the one type of bias, from the six above, most worth checking for in this dataset.

4. Write one question you could ask the community to help fill the gap or check the bias.

The dataset	Who or what may add understanding	The bias type most worth checking	One question to ask the community

> Tip: If you are not sure which bias type applies, start with “who was counted, and who was not?”. That question opens most of the others.

Try this now: notice one form of knowledge your data does not hold

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Think about a piece of data work you are involved in. Then fill in the table.

1. Name the data work and the main dataset behind it.

2. Name one form of local, cultural, or lived knowledge that would enhance this dataset.

3. Write how that knowledge has changed, or might change or deepen, what the data seems to show.

4. Write one respectful step you have taken, or could take next, to include it, such as who to ask, or what consent is needed.

The data work	Knowledge the data does not hold	How it might change the reading	One respectful next step

> Tip: Keep names, locations, and identifying details out of the table. Some cultural knowledge carries protocols about what can be shared onward, so record only what you have permission to record.

Try this now: reframe one finding

Apply Apply to your place 1

Take a real finding from your work that is commonly framed as a problem. Then fill in the table.

1. Write the finding as it is often stated, in its deficit framing.
2. Name one strength, asset, or sign of progress that sits alongside it.
3. Rewrite the finding so it acknowledges the challenge and points to potential and action.
4. Note one word you changed, and why the new word invites action.

The finding, deficit framing	A strength alongside it	The finding, reframed	One word changed, and why

> Tip: A strengths-based reframe still tells the truth about the challenge. It adds the strength and the next step; it does not hide the problem.

Try this now: build one strengths-based reading

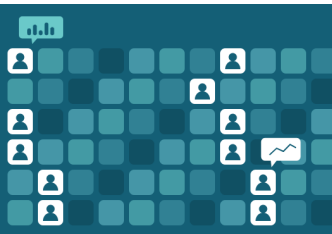
Apply Apply to your place 2

Take one dataset or finding you are working with. Then fill in the table.

1. Choose one of the five moves above to apply.
2. Name the challenge the data shows, stated truthfully.
3. Name the strength, asset, or progress you will show alongside it.
4. Write the next step or shared action you will end on.

The move you chose	The challenge, stated truthfully	The strength shown alongside	The next step to end on

> Tip: If you can only find the challenge and not the strength, that is a sign to bring community members into the reading before you report it.



Understanding & using data together

Module

3.1 Deeper understanding of context

Section 1	Backbone teams	2 activities
Section 2	Governance, Terms of Reference, and data governance	2 activities
Section 3	Inclusive governance, networks, and community ecosystems	2 activities

Try this now: name the group, and who coordinates it

Apply Apply to your place 1

Pick one group, initiative or partnership you are part of or work alongside. This is the group you will use for the rest of the module, so choose one you know well enough to answer questions about.

If you are not working with a group at the moment, use one you have worked with before, or one you are trying to get started.

Fill in the table below. In the last column, name one specific thing that would stop happening, not a general worry: the quarterly report nobody else knows how to pull together, the relationship with the local health service, the shared calendar.

The group or initiative I am thinking about	Who holds the coordination work together now (person, role or organisation)	Is that a named and resourced role, or does it happen on top of other work	One thing that would stop if that person stepped away

> Keep this table. Everything else you fill in over the next three sections is about this group.

Try this now: check who carries each function

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Stay with the group you named above. For each of the three functions, write down who carries it at the moment, whether it is resourced, and one thing community data work could add.

If a row has no answer in the second column, that is the finding: you have located a function that is running on nobody.

“Resourced” here means more than money. Note whether there is paid time, cultural labour that is recognised and paid for, meeting space, or data access attached to the function.

The function	Who carries it now	Is it resourced, and how	What community data work could add here
Identifying and securing funding and resources			
Convening stakeholders, community champions and volunteers			
Facilitating agreement on shared purpose and ways of working			

> Look down the second column. A function with no name against it is the first thing to raise at your next meeting, and it is usually easier to raise as a question about the function than as a question about a person.

Try this now: check what your Terms of Reference covers

Apply Apply to your place 1

Stay with the group you named in Section 1. Work through the five things a Terms of Reference sets out, and mark honestly what yours says about each. “We have no Terms of Reference” is a legitimate answer and a useful finding.

In the last column, name the person or group who would need to agree any change to that line. That column is often the more revealing one, because it shows where authority actually sits.

What a Terms of Reference sets out	Does ours say this? (yes, partly, no, or we have no ToR)	Who would need to agree the wording
Purpose and scope of the group		
Roles and responsibilities, and where authority sits		
How decisions are made, and which ones need broader community input		
How community perspectives, lived experience and cultural authority are represented		
How disagreement, tension or conflict is addressed		

> Every “partly”, “no” or blank in the middle column is an item for your governance stocktake. You will add data to this list in the second exercise.

Try this now: draft the data lines for your Terms of Reference

Apply | Apply to your place 2

A strong Terms of Reference includes a clear section on data governance. The six rows below are what that section covers. For each one, write your group's current position in a single line, as it stands today rather than as you would like it to be, then name who would need to agree it.

You are drafting, not finalising. A line that reads "we have not discussed this" is a useful entry, because it turns an assumption into an agenda item.

What the Terms of Reference needs to say about data	Our position in one line	Who needs to agree this
Community ownership and control of data		
Decision-making authority over data use		
Consent and cultural protocols		
Data sharing and access arrangements		
Use of data for learning, accountability, shared measurement, evaluation and advocacy		
How and when data governance gets reviewed		

> Writing these down is what makes data governance visible, deliberate and enforceable. Put this table beside the Terms of Reference gap check from the first exercise: together they are the governance half of your stocktake, and they are specific enough to take to a meeting.

Try this now: who is shaping the decisions, and who is not

Apply Apply to your place 1

Stay with the group from Sections 1 and 2. Fill in the table for two people or groups who are affected by the group's decisions but are not shaping them. Be specific about who, rather than writing a category.

In the third column, name what is actually keeping them out: the meeting time, the cost of getting there, the language the papers are written in, the fact that the last engagement went badly. In the fourth, name one change you could put to the group at its next meeting, not a full redesign.

Who is shaping decisions now	Who is affected but not here	What is keeping them out	One change I could propose

> Two rows is enough to start. If the third column keeps coming back to the same barrier, you have found something structural rather than personal, and that is a stronger thing to raise.

Try this now: one gap, one connection, one element

Apply Apply to your place 2

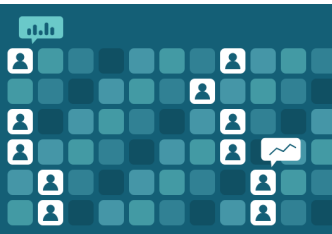
Look back at the two rows you filled in earlier, and at the backbone functions with no owner from Section 1. Pick one gap. Name which kind it is, using the three types above, then work out the connection that would help close it and which of the 12 Elements it would strengthen.

Naming the element is what turns a useful introduction into something you can explain to a governance group and a funder.

The last column is the one that makes this real: who has the first conversation, and roughly when.

The gap	Participation, capability or influence?	The connection that would help close it	Which of the 12 Elements it strengthens	Who has the first conversation, and when

> One connection, deliberately chosen and explained, tends to do more than five made because they were available. If the third column names an organisation rather than a person, find the person: relationships are held by people.



Understanding & using data together

Module

3.2 Data ecosystem mapping and custodian engagement

Section 1	Map the ecosystem, and find who holds the data	2 activities
Section 2	Ask well and understand what no means	2 activities
Section 3	From trust to agreement	2 activities

Try this now: map one question to its data

Apply Apply to your place 1

Take one question you need answered at the moment, the kind a colleague or community member has asked you. Fill in the row below. In the second column, name which of the four data types would answer it. In the fourth, say how you will check whether it is already public.

The question I need answered	Type of place-based data	Who is likely to hold it	Open or private, and how I will check	What it would let us do

Example you can use

No live question right now? Use this one: “How many local families waited more than a month for a housing support appointment last year?”

Try this now: find the way to one custodian

Apply Apply to your place 2

Take the custodian you named in the first exercise and work out how you would reach them. You are not sending anything yet. You are working out how to approach them and what rules apply.

Custodian	Data I want	Already published anywhere?	How to ask (open portal, Dataplace, direct request, ethics or research governance)	Rules that apply	My first step, and by when

Example you can use

No live request? Use this one: a state government department holds waiting time data for a local service, and you want it broken down by suburb.

Try this now: write the purpose, then test it

Apply Apply to your place 1

Write the purpose of your request in plain language, then check it against the list. If you cannot answer a row, that row is your next piece of work.

Your purpose, in one or two sentences a community member would understand:

Check	Can you answer yes?
Clear purpose: can I explain why this data is needed?	
Defined use: do I know how it will be analysed and used?	
Right access: is it clear who will access it and how it is protected?	
Decision-focused: do I know what decisions or actions it will inform?	
Community benefit: can I explain how this helps the community or place?	
Safety and storage: can I explain how the data will be governed and safely stored?	
Minimal request: am I only asking for the data that is genuinely needed?	
Plain language: can I explain the purpose in simple, non-technical language?	

> If you cannot explain the purpose clearly to a community member or a data custodian, the request is not ready yet.

Try this now: plan the conversation before the request

Apply Apply to your place 2

Take the custodian you identified in Section 1, or the one you are closest to approaching, and plan the conversation that happens before anything formal is submitted. The third column is the one people skip: write down what you want to learn from them, not only what you want to get.

Who I am, and who I represent	Who else is involved	What I want to understand from them	Limits or risks I will name upfront	What I will do if the answer is no

Example you can use

No live request? Use this one: you are approaching a local service provider for de-identified appointment waiting times, on behalf of a partnership of three organisations.

Try this now: plan what you give back

Apply Apply to your place 1

Take the custodian from your request and plan the reciprocity before you need it. This is often what decides whether there is a second request.

What I will share back	Who it goes to	When, and how often	How I will credit their contribution	Something useful I can offer easily

Example you can use

No live request? Use this one: a service provider has agreed to share de-identified waiting time data with your partnership for twelve months.

Try this now: draft the outline of an agreement

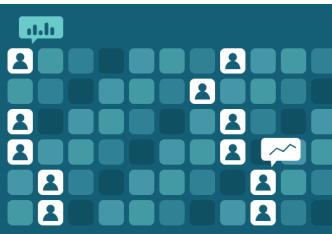
Apply Apply to your place 2

You are not writing a legal document. You are writing the six things a partner would need to agree with you before anyone brings in a template. Each row maps to one of the MOU points above.

Part of the agreement	Your draft
Shared purpose: why we are working together	
Community benefit: what changes for people here	
Guiding principles: the values this partnership works to	
Roles: who does what, and who is accountable	
Governance: who decides, and how community voice is included	
Review: what will trigger us revisiting this, and when	

Example you can use

No live request? Use this one: a partnership of three organisations and a service provider, sharing de-identified appointment data for twelve months to understand local waiting times.



Understanding & using data together

Module

3.3 Evidence development

Section 1	Apply systems thinking to frame the challenge	2 activities
Section 2	Develop an evidence-based community story	2 activities
Section 3	The Understanding, Measurement, Evaluation and Learning (UMEL) framework	2 activities

Try this now: map the factors behind one local issue

Apply Apply to your place 1

Take one issue you are working on. In the table below, name a few factors that affect it, such as a policy, a funding rule, a service practice or a community strength.

For each factor, note how it affects the issue, and whether that influence pushes the issue up (+) or down (–). This is the start of a factor map.

A factor that affects the issue	How it affects the issue	Direction (+ or –)

Example you can use

No live issue right now? Use this one: young people in a town are disengaging from school.

Try this now: look beneath one event with the Iceberg Model

Apply Apply to your place 2

Take one visible event or problem in your work. Use the table to move down through the levels of the iceberg, discussed earlier: the pattern over time, the structures that shape it, and the beliefs or assumptions that hold it in place.

You do not need every box filled in; the aim is to look below the surface.

Iceberg level	What I notice or would ask about this event
Event (what we see)	
Patterns and trends (over time)	
Structures (what is causing the pattern)	
Mental models (beliefs holding it in place)	

Example you can use

No live example right now? Use this one: residents say they feel less connected to their community than they did a decade ago.

Try this now: map what you already know about one community goal

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Take one concern or goal that matters to a community you work with. In the table, note what data already exists, who owns or controls it, whose voice might be missing, and how well it fits your place. This is the start of a data map.

The community goal or concern	Data that already exists	Who owns or controls it	Whose voice is missing, and how well it fits your place

Example you can use

No live goal right now? Use this one: families want children to arrive at school ready to learn.

Try this now: draft the outline of a case for change

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Take one issue a community has raised. Use the table to sketch the four parts of a case for change in a few words each. This is a first draft to test and revise with community, not a finished document.

Part of the case for change	In a few words
What is happening now (the baseline)	
Why this matters here	
What happens if nothing changes	
What success would look like	

Example you can use

No live issue right now? Use this one: there is nowhere safe for teenagers to gather after school.

Try this now: design one part of UMEL with community in mind

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Take one change a community wants to see. In the table, note how you would know the change was happening, and one simple, safe way you could notice or track it with community. Keep it manageable and respectful.

The change community wants to see	How we would notice it was happening	A simple, safe way to track it

Example you can use

No live example right now? Use this one: people in the community feel more connected and able to support one another.

Try this now: turn commitment into action

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Think about a piece of work where you want UMEL to take hold. In the table, name one action you could start now, one longer-term commitment that needs ongoing support, and who needs to be involved to make it happen.

One immediate action	One longer-term commitment	Who needs to be involved

Example you can use

No live example right now? Use this one: a partnership wants to show funders how a youth program is making a difference.